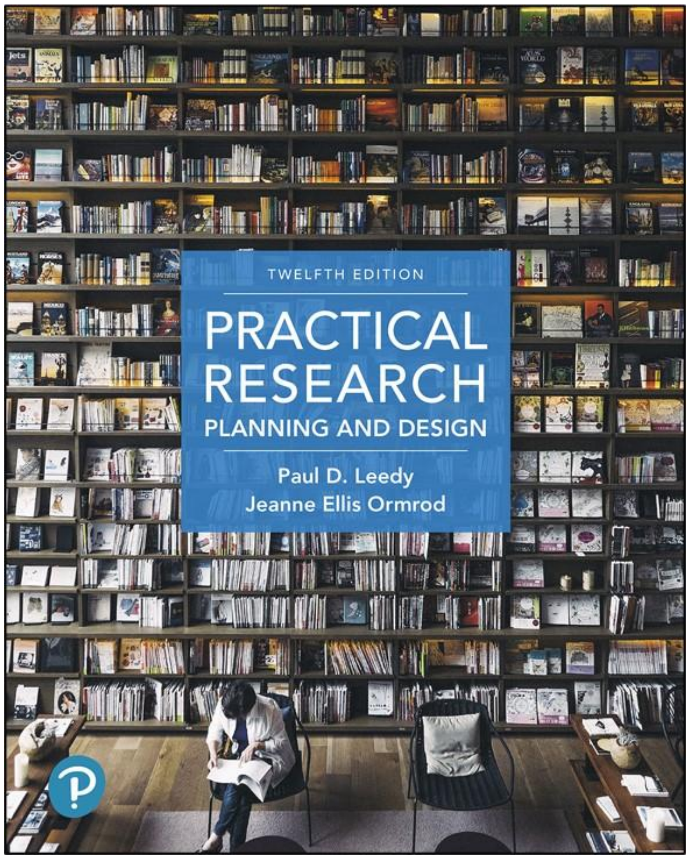
Practical Research: Planning and Design

Twelfth Edition



Chapter 8

Qualitative Research Methods

Pearson

Potential Advantages of Qualitative Research

- Exploration
- Multifaceted description
- Verification
- Theory development
- Problem identification
- Evaluation

Research Problems

- Qualitative studies do not allow the researcher to identify cause–and–effect relationships
- May be general and open-ended
  - “What is the nature of…”
  - “What is it like to…”

Research Methodology

- May not be determined in advance
- May continue to evolve over the course of the study
- Requires considerable preparation and planning

Qualitative Research Designs

- Case study
- Ethnography
- Phenomenological study
- Grounded theory study
- Narrative Inquiry
- Content analysis

Case Study (1 of 2)

- A particular individual, program or event is studied in depth
- Used for
  - Learning more about a little known or poorly understood situation
  - Investigating how an individual or program changes over time
  - Generating or providing preliminary support for one or more hypotheses

Case Study (2 of 2)

- Limitation: findings may not be generalizable to other situations

Ethnography (1 of 2)

- In-depth investigation of an entire group that shares a common culture
  - Site-based field work
  - Performed in natural setting
  - Performed over long period of time
  - Key informants
  - Often involves participant observation

Ethnography (2 of 2)

- Used to study
  - Explicit cultural patterns
  - Implicit beliefs and assumptions
  - Below-the-surface, taken-for-granted patterns that even group members aren’t always consciously aware of

Narrative Inquiry

- Used for studying complex, multifaceted phenomena
  - Focuses on the recollections and stories of individuals who have had experiences related to these phenomena
  - Central notion: Three-dimensional narrative space comprised of interaction, continuity, and situation

Phenomenological Study

- Study that attempts to understand people's perceptions and perspectives of a particular experience
  - Small sample
  - Lengthy unstructured interviews

Grounded Theory Study

- Goal is to collect and interpret data to develop a theory
  - Data analysis begins right away
  - Data are organized into categories until **saturation**
  - Theory emerges from interrelations among categories
- Typically focused on a **process**
  - eating, class discussions, stress during work

Content Analysis

- Detailed, systematic examination of the contents of a body of material
  - Books, newspapers, legal documents, transcripts of conversations, blogs
- Often included along with another study design
- Often has a quantitative component
  - Identify categories & count frequency in each

Collecting Qualitative Data (1 of 2)

- Multiple methods are used
  - Example: interview + observation + artifacts
- Many qualitative researchers engage in the production of memos
- Data collection follows an emerging design
- Analysis of early data influences additional data collection
- Researchers write memos during data collection

Collecting Qualitative Data (2 of 2)

- All data must be collected in an ethical way
  - Informed consent
  - Right to privacy
  - Low risk

Credibility and Transferability

- Equivalent to validity and reliability in quantitative research.
- Whereas quantitative researcher judge assessment strategies as reliable, qualitative researchers prefer to speak of dependability.

Strategies to Enhance Credibility and Reliability

- Identifying biases (reflexivity)
- Collecting multiple forms of data (triangulation)
- Separating observations (data) from interpretations (memos)
- Seeking exceptions and contradictory evidence
- Spending considerable time on site
- Member checking and audit trails

Selecting an Appropriate Sample (1 of 3)

- Depends on your research question and goal
  - Random samples best for generalizing to a larger population
  - Purposive samples best when specific information/perspective is needed
  - Grounded theorists tend to engage in:
    - Theoretical sampling
    - Discriminant sampling

Selecting an Appropriate Sample (2 of 3)

- Case study researchers may engage in **extreme case sampling**: A researcher selects individuals who have unique or deviant characteristics within a case, then focuses observations on those individuals
- When researchers have little control over certain situations they may employ:
  - convenience sampling
  - snowball sampling

Selecting an Appropriate Sample (3 of 3)

- Ideally, the sample should provide information not only about how things are **on average** but also about how much **variability** exists in the phenomenon under investigation.

Observations

- Typically unstructured, free-flowing
- Can be very time-consuming
- Can be biased
  - Researcher's attention
  - Researcher's interpretations
  - Researcher's influence on participant

Interviews (1 of 3)

1. Identify general questions and follow-up questions in advance
2. Consider participants' cultural backgrounds
3. Make sure sample includes people who can give the information you want
4. Find a suitable location

Interviews (2 of 3)

5. Get written permission
6. Establish and maintain rapport
7. Focus on the actual rather than on the abstract or hypothetical
8. Don’t put words in people’s mouths

Interviews (3 of 3)

9. Record responses verbatim
10. Keep your reactions to yourself
11. Remember that you may not be getting the “facts”
12. When conducting a focus group, take group dynamics into account

Criteria for Evaluating Qualitative Research (1 of 4)

1. Purposefulness
   – The research question drives the methods used to collect and analyze data.
2. Explicitness of assumptions and biases
   – The researcher identifies and communicates anything that may influence data collection and interpretation.
3. Rigor
   – The researcher uses rigorous, precise, and thorough methods and takes steps to remain as objective as possible.

Criteria for Evaluating Qualitative Research (2 of 4)

4. Open-mindedness
   – The researcher shows a willingness to modify hypotheses and interpretations when necessary.
5. Completeness
   – The researcher develops an in-depth, multifaceted picture of the phenomenon (i.e., thick description).
6. Coherence
   – The researcher uses converging data to develop a portrait that "hangs together".

Criteria for Evaluating Qualitative Research (3 of 4)

7. Persuasiveness
   - The researcher presents logical arguments, and the weight of the evidence supports them.
8. Consensus
   - Other individuals agree with the researcher’s interpretations and explanations.

Criteria for Evaluating Qualitative Research (4 of 4)

9. Usefulness
   - The project leads to
     - A better understanding of the phenomenon
     - More accurate predictions about future events
     - Interventions that enhance the quality of life

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